

Sonos Ace

Premium sound meets sleek design

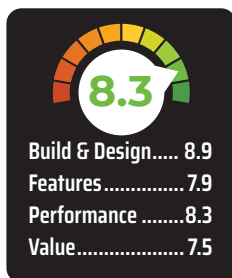
Sonos has entered the high-end headphone market with the new Ace headphones, a bold debut that sets its sights on heavyweights like Sony's WH-1000XM5 and Apple's AirPods Max. Responding to overwhelming demand from Sonos enthusiasts, the company has carefully crafted the Ace headphones to embody the iconic Sonos design philosophy, delivering elegance in every detail. As one would expect from Sonos products, the Sonos Ace headphones prioritise audio excellence, capturing the premium sound Sonos is known for, while seamlessly integrating with other Sonos devices for a unified listening experience. Yet, in a market already rich with premium choices, how do the Sonos Ace headphones truly measure up? Let's explore their design, audio quality, noise cancellation, battery performance, and standout features that distinguish them in this competitive landscape.

DESIGN AND COMFORT

The Sonos Ace is undoubtedly a premium product, and its price reflects that. While it's priced slightly higher than competitors like Bose, Sony, and Sennheiser, it remains more affordable than Apple's AirPods Max in India. The premium cost feels justified given the Ace's superior build quality. From the mirror-finish metal under the headband to the high-grade plastic earcups, every material used exudes quality and elegance. The headband and earcups feature memory foam padding wrapped in high-end faux leather, adding to the luxurious feel.

The Ace has a solid heft, weighing 312 g, that suggests durability, capable of withstanding regular travel without compromising comfort. Despite the weight,

₹39,999



it doesn't feel heavy on the head, maintaining a comfortable fit during extended wear.

True to Sonos' ethos of minimalistic, modern design, the Ace sports a sleek, streamlined look. The rounded earcups have no unnecessary trimmings, with just a single button on the left and two buttons on the right. Sonos has implemented magnetically attached, removable earcup paddings, which is a clever touch that makes pad replacements easy. The padding has a two-tone mesh in light and dark grey, however, the R and L indicators on the earbuds are too subtle and not easy to notice.

The Ace fits securely and exerts just enough pressure through the headband and earcups to stay in place. While it may not be the type of headphone that "disappears" on your head, it remains comfortable for prolonged use. However, I did notice my ears getting slightly toasty

when wearing these in Mumbai's sweltering October heat.

One standout feature of the Sonos Ace is its physical buttons, which are more intuitive than touch controls often found on other premium headphones. The left cup houses the power and pairing button, which requires a brief press-and-hold. The right cup has two buttons: one toggles between noise-cancellation and transparency mode, and the second is a versatile slider that adjusts volume and doubles as a play/pause button. These controls are slick, precise, and functional; something many users will appreciate.

The Ace comes with a well-designed case that complements its premium feel. Inside, a magnetically attached pouch holds both the charging and analogue cables, giving users the option for wired or wireless listening.

SOUND QUALITY

True to Sonos' preferred audio signature, the Ace headphones are tuned for precision and clarity. The Sonos Ace headphones feature custom-designed 40 mm dynamic drivers. Rather than heavily boosting bass, Sonos has taken a more balanced approach, albeit it leans a bit towards the warmer side. You get a detailed sound profile that shines across genres. From complex classical compositions to vocal-heavy tracks, these headphones deliver a rich, dynamic sound.

They're neither as neutral as the AirPods Max nor as bass-biased as the Sony WH-1000XM5. You get a warm, full-bodied sound signature that has enough punch without veiling the intricate details in the mid-range or the highs. Speaking of the highs, they're high on detail and have a pleasant sparkle. Instrument separation is fantastic and the soundstage is pretty decent too.

For bass enthusiasts though, the more conservative low-end might feel a bit underwhelming, especially compared to competitors that cater to bass-driven genres like EDM and hip-hop. Yet, Sonos' approach will appeal to those who appreciate a more natural sound that highlights mid-range details and subtle nuances.